Learning & Development Budget Policy

1. Overview

The Learning & Development (L&D) Budget Policy for the Engineering folder at Larkspur Freight outlines the annual allocation, approval process, and usage guidelines for employee training. The policy applies to all full-time engineering staff across our Chicago, Dallas, and Portland offices. The goal is to ensure continuous skill development and alignment with company objectives. The annual L&D budget for engineering is set at $48,000 for FY2024, with individual allocations and office-specific rules detailed below.

2. Eligibility and Coverage

All full-time engineers (including DevOps, QA, and Data Engineering) who have completed at least 90 days of employment are eligible. Contractors and interns are not covered. Covered expenses include:
• Online courses (e.g., CodeSpring, SkillForge)
• Certification exams (e.g., AWS, Azure)
• Conference attendance (registration, travel, and lodging)
• Technical books and subscriptions (up to $300/year per employee)
Employees may request up to $2,000 per calendar year, subject to manager approval.

3. Budget Allocation by Office

The $48,000 annual budget is distributed as follows:
• Chicago: $22,000 (HQ, 44 FTEs)
• Dallas: $16,000 (32 FTEs)
• Portland: $10,000 (20 FTEs)
Unused funds do not roll over. Each office's Engineering Manager is responsible for tracking local spend and reporting monthly to the Director of Engineering.

4. Approval Process

Employees must submit a Learning Request Form via the Larkspur HR Portal at least 15 business days before the training start date. The direct manager reviews and either approves or denies within 5 business days. For requests over $1,500, Director of Engineering (currently Priya Nand) approval is also required. All requests must include:
• Vendor name (e.g., SkillForge, DevSummit)
• Itemized costs
• Justification for training
Receipts must be uploaded within 10 days of completion for reimbursement.

5. Preferred Vendors and Tools

Larkspur Freight has negotiated discounts with the following vendors:
• CodeSpring (15% off all courses)
• SkillForge (10% off group workshops)
• DevSummit (conference partner)

Employees are encouraged to use these vendors when possible. Requests for non-preferred vendors require an additional justification and may be subject to longer approval times.

6. Reporting and Compliance

Engineering Managers must submit a quarterly L&D spend report to finance@larkspurfreight.com by the 10th of the following month. Reports should include:
• Employee name
• Training type and vendor
• Amount spent
• Completion status
Finance will audit 10% of claims annually. Non-compliance (e.g., missing receipts, unapproved vendors) may result in loss of L&D privileges for the following year.

7. Exceptions and Special Cases

Requests exceeding the $2,000 annual cap or for international travel require VP of Engineering (currently Marcus Lee) approval. Exceptions are considered on a case-by-case basis and must be submitted at least 30 days in advance. Emergency training (e.g., compliance updates) may be fast-tracked with Director approval. For questions, contact lnd@larkspurfreight.com.